PROLOGUE

On 20 October 1994, *Thaniniram*, a Malayalam eveninger, broke a story of a woman spy being arrested in Trivandrum. It spoke about a woman called Mariam Rasheeda, 38, a Maldivian spy on a mission to Trivandrum to get secret drawings of Indian rocket engines.

CPM mouthpiece *Desabhimani* followed up the story the next morning. Two days after the Maldivian woman's arrest, *Kerala Kaumudi*, another Malayalam daily, dropped a bombshell: Inspector General of Police Raman Srivastava, an officer considered a favourite of Chief Minister K Karunakaran, has links with the spy ring.

On 13 November 1994, the local police arrested another Maldivian woman, a friend of Mariam, called Fauziyya Hassan. Soon, virtually every vernacular newspaper in Kerala was reporting the spy case. Mariam, the reports said, served as a honey trap with Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) scientists to cart away drawings and documents of the cryogenic engine to her masters in Pakistan. Though Mariam Rasheeda, said to be a contract employee of the Maldives Government on a primary mission to gather information about a possible coup being planned against Maldives President Maumoon Abdul Gayoom, was first booked under the Foreigners Act for overstay, another case was filed under the Official Secrets Act.

The Kerala Police made more arrests by the end of the month and the list of accused included K Chandrasekhar, a Bangalore-based Indian representative of Russian space agency Glavkosmos; D Sasikumaran, deputy director, cryogenic project, ISRO; S Nambi Narayanan, director, cryogenic project, ISRO and S K Sharma, a Bangalore-based labour contractor. The Kerala Police formed a Special Investigation Team (SIT)